Object Permanence Is Not a Single Staircase

Looking-time studies report sensitivity to occlusion events in young infants; usable search appears later and depends on action demands. Looking and reaching measure different layers, not one completed object concept.

DE: MODERATE-LOOKING-SENSITIVITY; LOW-COMPLETE-CONCEPT | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: COGNITION | REPLICATION: VERIF

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Piaget's search tasks placed usable object permanence near the end of the first year because they required coordinated action. Baillargeon (1987) used a drawbridge/occlusion looking-time design: 4.5-month-olds, and some 3.5-month-olds, looked longer at an "impossible" rotation through the space of a hidden box than at a possible rotation. That is evidence of sensitivity to an occlusion event in a looking measure. It is not by itself a complete, action-ready object concept.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

Baillargeon (1987), Developmental Psychology: experimental contrast of possible vs impossible events after habituation, with a control condition that lacked the box. Identification is looking-time, not search. Later commentary (including Aslin 2007 and subsequent VoE critiques) treats linking hypotheses as open. Competence and performance can diverge: an infant may look longer at an impossible event and still fail a manual search that requires means–end coordination.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

The outcome is contemporaneous looking, not later physics competence. Persistence of a "concept" across tasks is exactly what this literature does not settle.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a (laboratory cognitive developmental task, not an observational population phenotype association).

Salience, rotation extent, habituation criteria, and trial structure can change looking. Small classic samples. Replication and alternative perceptual accounts remain live. Task demands (looking vs reaching vs multiple objects) are not noise; they are part of the claim.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Does not mean young infants are miniature physicists. Does not mean Piaget should be discarded as a whole. Does not mean a missed peekaboo writes a cognitive fate. Core-knowledge slogans are not this card.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Ordinary play with disappearing and reappearing objects is consistent with the finding. Object-permanence toys as cognitive enhancement are not justified.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Baillargeon (1987), Developmental Psychology (DOI 10.1037/0012-1649.23.5.655)